Land of the Dead

By Neil LaBute

MAN: Wow. What a day I mean, *what* a day, right?

WOMAN: I'll never forget it .

MAN: You know, because, it's not ... that kinda thing doesn't just come around any ol' time of the week, thank God. Huh? That's one of those dates that gets in your head and stays there. Like, ahh ... ahh ...

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *It's early morning – September 11, 2001 – A few hours before the Twin Towers in New York were attacked by Islamist Extremists.*
ACTOR: *A few hours of "normal" – Well, not quite normal – thought we tried hard to convince ourselves that what we had planned for the day was no big deal*
ACTRESS: *A few hours before we found ourselves in*
TOGETHER: *The Land of the Dead by Neil LaBute*

*Silence. Darkness. Lights up slowly on a **MAN** and a **WOMAN**.*

WOMAN: I got up around three that morning, I remember that. Very clearly. It was dark out our window and I just couldn't sleep. Maybe three-thirty but no later than that. *(Beat.)* He was still snoring . . .

MAN: I was out cold. I mean, completely zonked. I'd been out with some of the guys I work with. We'd closed a big deal that afternoon and you gotta take a minute, pound the ol' fists on the chest a bit when something good happens, right? Anyway, I slept great . . .

WOMAN: I go to my purse and begin to count the money again. That's stupid to do, I know, I know that, I must've checked the thing, like, *sixty* times already. I count it out again. Should be four hundred dollars. In tens . . .

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MAN: She made me go out to an ATM that night! She's sitting up when I get in, just after midnight, and she's just staring at me ... says I shouldn't have taken any money from there without telling her - I snagged a few bills out for the bar - and I need to go back out. So I empty my wallet, but it's no good. We're fifty bucks short. Great. I'm looking at her face and I know not to argue. I just slip my jacket back on and head down to the corner.

WOMAN: I was waiting for him to get that money - I didn't care about his being out that night. Not like it was some big surprise - I just wanted the rest of the cash. I suppose we could've just written a check, but I wanted to pay it, bill by bill, putting it out there on the counter, so I'd remember. So I'd feel it. Feel something.

MAN: Normally I would go with her, no question. Seriously. We'd talked about it and I promised I would and so, yeah, under *normal* circumstances I totally would've been there. But the boss is all over me this morning, wants to go to breakfast, he's calling my cell by six o'clock - he's so happy with our closing that account - I *have* to go... anyhow, once I explain it, she completely understands ...

WOMAN: Typical, right? He leaves it up to me ... but what're you gonna do? He'd just sit there, anyway, reading *People* magazine and checking his watch, so forget it ... at that point we'd decided, we're doing it, might as well just get it done.

MAN: She leaves a little bit before me ... maybe ten minutes ahead. This peck on the cheek and she takes off. Leaves the stupid money on the table! So I'm running downstairs in my bare feet to catch her ... believe that?

WOMAN: He comes barreling down the stairs, yelling out my name. For a second... I thought he wanted to talk, change of heart. I can recall turning around, this huge smile on my face .... then I see the envelope in his hand.

I took the earliest appointment I could ... seven-thirty. I thought that was the

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best thing, you know, just get it over with. Only have to use up half a personal day that way. *(Beat.)*

MAN: Breakfast is pretty decent. I have ham on the bone, and some sorta eggs. The boss is droning on and on about production and output . . .

WOMAN: They call my name . .

MAN: Food's good but the guy is driving me nuts, talking loud and this little bit of jelly hanging on his bottom lip as he's yakking away. I mean, hell, I might as well have gone with her to the clinic... least I could've read a *magazine* or something.

WOMAN: I'm perched on the edge of the table with that kind of crinkly paper under me ... and the nurse is saying something. I remember quite clearly: She said, "I love your hair." Then later, "There'll be some slight discomfort." *(Beat.)*

MAN: No, I'm pro-choice, I am ... she can choose to keep the kid, or she can choose to keep me. It's entirely up to her! *(Laughs.)* That's a joke, actually. *(Beat.)* But seriously, think about it . . . You do it, it happens, it's over. I've heard that it doesn't hurt that much at least no more than a pretty good paper cut. Now, I know, I know, there's a whole "psychological" thing going on, I know that. But come on ... we're still talking about, in essence, a *paper cut!*

WOMAN: And I don't really feel anything afterward. Nothing ... *(Beat.)* Someone comes in to check on me, so I get my things together and go up to the front to pay. At the last moment-I mean, I even reached out and snatched back the envelope-I decide to pay by credit card instead, which somehow seems, I don't know, appropriate.

MAN: Besides, we're sending it to a better place, right? Better than this world, anyways ... Or maybe not. Maybe it is wrong, hell, I don't know... Not that I wouldn't've taken care of it. No, seriously! I can see myself buying toys, changing diapers, stuff like that ... *(Beat.)* Of course, all that's easier to say

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knowing that the little bundle's safely in some incinerator somewhere. *(Beat.)* Anyway, I leave her a message on my way to the office ...

WOMAN: I stop on the street and listen to him. And as he speaks, he just casually tosses this in: "I tried phoning you earlier, but I couldn't get through ... "

MAN: I tried a couple times before I ate, I really did ... but she's always switching the power thing off on the side there. Drives me nuts!

WOMAN: He says, "Cause I was gonna say, I mean, if you wanna, we can go ahead and just keep the thing. Up to you." *(Beat.)* I stand there for a minute, supporting myself against the metal doorjamb. And then I say out loud, "Too late ... it's too *late*. I already did it ... " And I'm okay, it's ... it's no problem. The only ... I shouldn't even bring this up, but ... *(Beat.)* I keep hearing that sound. That buzzing, you know, from the ... I'm still aware of it. *(Listens.)*

MAN: Anyhow, I get upstairs, over to my cubicle, and just kick back for a second. Look out at the city. Up here, in these cloud-capped towers, all your worries and fears and just, you know, bad *stuff* ... melts into air, into thin air. The sky's clear as anything. All blue. Makes you feel, I dunno ... alive, I guess ...

For a moment, the earsplitting sound of Jet aircraft. Deafening. The light over the MAN slowly goes out. The WOMAN removes a cell phone from her purse.

WOMAN: I kept trying his phone after . . . ringing it, just ringing it and hoping that he'd pick up. For a few days, actually ... but he didn't. He never did ... *(Beat.)* I still have that message he left me, the one about not going through with it, about keeping the ... I play it at night sometimes, when I'm lying there, missing him. Both of them.

She presses a button and holds the phone to her ear.

MAN: *(off-stage)* "Hey, it's me - breakfast was okay, not bad. Anyway, I tried you earlier, but, listen... I was gonna say, I mean, if you wanna, we can go ahead and just keep the thing. Up to you. Or whatever... 'Kay. Buzz me later. Love ya."

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WOMAN: It's funny, the stuff you remember. Well, not *funny*, but, you know. Yeah ...

(Listens.) There's that buzzing again - is that my phone, or...? Do you hear that?

Do you? Listen ...

She checks her cell phone again, then looks around, searching. Silence. Darkness.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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